

Figure 2.24 *Taq-i Bustan, central Iran, column capital (Sasanian). Kröger 1982: tafel 40.*

remains in the adjacent parts of Ghur should not elicit surprise. Indeed, the Islamic-Umayyad and -Abbasid extensions into Sistan during the late seventh through eighth centuries did not progress unchecked, but rather were protracted over at least the next 150 years. Leaders with local power bases, such as the Saffarids (eighth–thirteenth centuries, with various suzerains), themselves arising from the earlier influx of Umayyad and Abbasid expeditionary forces, embarked on their own ongoing struggles for supremacy.[56]

The historical sources describe incessant confrontations between the Rutbils and – initially – the Umayyad- and Abbasid-deputed forces, and eventually Saffarid loyalists and others. "Rutbil" was likely a hereditary title for the rulers of Zabulistan, parts of al-Rukhkhaj, Zamindawar, and Sistan,[57] whose seasonal capitals were distributed between northern *sard-sir* or summering grounds in Zabul, and the southern *garm-sir* in Zamindawar in the winter months (map, p. xvi).[58] The military engagements between the enigmatic Rutbil's allied military contingents (including "Turks") and the equally varied, Islam-affiliated forces were frequent and ongoing at least up to the end of the ninth and likely into the tenth